

Take Action Against Cyberbullying!

What should we do about cyberbullying?

Grade

6-8

Subjects

ELA, Health/PE

Estimated Duration

16-20 instructional
hours

Key Content

bullying, persuasive
writing, research,
health advocacy,
digital citizenship,
social emotional
learning



Students discuss cyberbullying and learn about the issue through watching videos, engaging in online research, and reading informational text. Drawing on the upstander framework (<https://www.facinghistory.org/upstander>) and analysis of their existing school/district anti-cyberbullying policy/prevention program, teams create Public Service Announcements to speak out against cyberbullying and communicate evidence-based arguments advocating for a target audience in the community to take a stand alongside them.

Project Path

Project Launch

How and why is cyberbullying a problem for young adults?

Entry event: Engage in an anti-cyberbullying film festival and discuss the problem of cyberbullying and how it affects individuals and communities.

Preview the project, generate questions, form teams, and prepare for effective collaboration.

Build Knowledge and Develop & Critique

How can we respond when bullying occurs?

Learn about the roles of upstanders vs. bystanders in responding to bullying.

What are some of the causes, effects, and possible solutions to cyberbullying?

Research and explore the issue of cyberbullying to understand the problem and brainstorm ways to address the issue.

What can we do to address cyberbullying in our school community?

Examine existing anti-cyberbullying policies/ programs and the roles of various stakeholders, then brainstorm and select the target audience, message, and purpose for public service announcements.

How can we convince the community to take action on cyberbullying?

Write arguments and create public service announcements speaking out against cyberbullying and advocating for change.

Present Products

How can we engage the community in addressing cyberbullying?

Present PSAs to the community to speak out and call for change.

Make It Yours

Reflect on your students

- What kinds of social technologies do your students use in their daily lives?
- What do you know about students' experiences with bullying/cyberbullying? How will you create a safe environment for this project and work with students to establish and adhere to shared norms?
- How can you support students who may have experienced situations where bullying led to suicide? What additional

resources, such as school counselors or community support programs could you connect with?

- What aspects of bullying/cyberbullying do your students seem particularly interested in exploring?
- Are there cultural differences among your students that will affect how they approach or talk about the issue of cyberbullying?

How will you provide coaching and modeling to help students avoid labels when discussing the roles kids play in bullying (<https://www.stopbullying.gov/bullying/roles-kids-play>), for example “the person who bullied” rather than “bully” and “the person who was bullied” rather than “victim.”

Reflect on your context

- What technology/media tools do your students already know how to use that could be helpful in the project?
- Could you bring in outside experts to the project to provide content expertise or assist with the creation of Public Service Announcements?

Reflect on the content & skills

- How will you identify (and scaffold students’ access to) various levels of informational text on the topic of cyberbullying?
- What types of models and examples might be most helpful to students as they develop their argumentative writing?
- What specific collaboration or communication skills might you want to teach and assess through this project? How will you scaffold these skills?

Take It Further

Here are some ideas for expanding this project if you choose to do so:

- Use the 3-2-1 Bridge routine (<https://pz.harvard.edu/resources/3-2-1-bridge>) to help students reflect on their learning and insights throughout the project.
- After the “film festival,” have them record their three thoughts/ideas, two questions, and one analogy about cyberbullying on an exit ticket (<https://my.pblworks.org/resource/exit-tickets>). After reviewing their responses, set these aside for students to revisit later in the project.
- After producing their PSAs, ask students to write about their current questions and ideas, then return the exit tickets from the first step.
- Invite them to compare and connect their two sets of responses and write a reflection about their learning over the course of the project.
- Additional information about the 3-2-1 Bridge strategy can be found here (<http://www.rcsthinkfromthemiddle.com/3-2-1-bridge.html>).
- Provide additional time and structures for processing the articles that define/describe cyberbullying using a Text Rendering Experience (<https://www.schoolreforminitiative.org/download/text-rendering-experience-for-youth-engagement/>), Word-Phrase-Sentence (<https://pz.harvard.edu/resources/word-phrase-sentence>), or Sentence-Phrase-Word thinking routine (<http://www.rcsthinkfromthemiddle.com/sentence-phrase-word.html>).
- Direct students to this Social Media, Cyberbullying, and Online Safety Glossary (<https://cyberbullying.org/social-media-cyberbullying-and-online-safety-glossary>) to support their comprehension as they research and read about cyberbullying.
- Have students learn more about cyberbullying by reading young adult fiction about the issue, such as these young adult novels:
 - Booked (<https://books.google.com/books/about/Booked.html?id=et4dswEACAAJ>) by Kwame Alexander
 - Posted (<https://books.google.com/books/about/Posted.html?id=MHDUDAAAQBAJ>) by John David Anderson
 - Awkward (<https://www.google.com/books/edition/Awkward/219szQEACAAJ?hl=en>) by Svetlana Chmakova
 - Brave (https://books.google.com/books/about/Brave.html?id=MY_qjwEACAAJ) by Svetlana Chmakova
 - The Weight of Water (https://books.google.com/books/about/The_Weight_of_Water.html?id=kew_c-IMUBsC) by Sarah Crossan

- *If I Ever Get Out of Here*
(https://books.google.com/books/about/If_I_Ever_Get_Out_of_Here.html?id=AxjZMgEACAAJ) by Eric Gansworth
- *Letters to a Bullied Girl: Messages of Healing and Hope*
(https://books.google.com/books/about/Letters_to_a_Bullied_Girl.html?id=YVTKuEVcbD8C) by Olivia Gardner
- *The Mighty Odds*
(https://books.google.com/books/about/The_Mighty_Odds_The_Odds_Series_1.html?id=4XeqDAAAQBAJ) by Amy Ignatow
- *Finding Audrey* (https://books.google.com/books/about/Finding_Audrey.html?id=uPTdBAAAQBAJ) by Sophie Kinsella
- *I Funny: A Middle School Story* (https://books.google.com/books/about/I_Funny.html?id=1LiULHY6OmkC) by James Patterson
- *Bullyville* (<https://books.google.com/books/about/Bullyville.html?id=WAJkpAasqFgC>) by Francine Prose
- *Okay for Now* (https://books.google.com/books/about/Okay_for_Now.html?id=KN9G3zHwYZwC) by Gary D. Schmidt
- *Orbiting Jupiter* (https://books.google.com/books/about/Orbiting_Jupiter.html?id=0_zHBQAAQBAJ) by Gary D. Schmidt
- *Shooting Kabul* (https://books.google.com/books/about/Shooting_Kabul.html?id=OlSjBneMfWQC) by N. H. Senzai
- *Goodbye Stranger* (https://books.google.com/books/about/Goodbye_Stranger.html?id=X7IuCgAAQBAJ) by Rebecca Stead
- Have students anonymously survey students and others to gather information about how cyberbullying affects young people in the school community, learning about their experiences with and perspectives on cyberbullying (e.g., whether they are aware of existing policies and prevention programs, whether they've experienced or witnessed cyberbullying, and how they've responded).
- In addition to conducting surveys, have students *interview some of their peers* (<https://my.pblworks.org/resource/preparing-interviews>). Be sure to support students in the process of developing appropriate interview questions.
- Another option is for students to collaboratively develop three interview questions then engage in a *Microlabs protocol* (<https://www.schoolreforminitiative.org/download/microlabs/>) to share and hear classmates' perspectives and experiences. (Here are some videos of the Micro Lab protocol in action.)

- Give students the choice of creating an alternate media message in addition to a PSA, for example, a podcast, video, or social media campaign.
- Invite student journalists, school/district media, and/or local media to attend the event.
- If you are implementing this project in the fall semester, leverage the fact that October is National Bullying Prevention Month (<https://www.pacer.org/bullying/nbpm/>).

As an extension of the project, have students develop new or revised anti-cyberbullying policies for their school/district.

- To help students take a systems thinking approach to brainstorming ideas for their new/revised policies, begin by leading them through the Parts, People, Interactions routine (<https://pz.harvard.edu/resources/parts-people-interactions>).
- Have students individually generate ideas and propose new policies or improvements to existing policies to teammates using the Consensus Circle activity (<http://www.rcsthinkfromthemiddle.com/consensus-circle.html>). Compile a list of ideas that all team members are in support of including in their policy proposal.
- Guide students in writing a persuasive proposal that makes an evidence-based argument designed to convince school/district leaders to adopt their new/revised policy recommendations.
- Have students choose from a variety of formats for their anti-cyberbullying proposal: editorial essay, letter of appeal, research report, persuasive speech.
- Have students explore mentor texts for argumentative writing in general such as the Student Opinion (<https://www.nytimes.com/column/learning-student-opinion>) column and the Room for Debate (<https://www.nytimes.com/roomfordebate>) feature of the *New York Times*. The following student-produced examples of argumentative writing about bullying/cyberbullying are available from One World Education:
 - Anti-Bullying Programs: Do They Help Or Hurt? (<http://www.oneworldeducation.org/our-students-writing/anti-bullying-programs-do-they-help-or-hurt/>)
 - Cyber Bullying (<http://www.oneworldeducation.org/our-students-writing/cyber-bullying/>)
 - Done with Bullying! (<http://www.oneworldeducation.org/our-students-writing/done-with-bullying/>)
 - Let's Take Down Bullying! (<http://www.oneworldeducation.org/our-students-writing/lets-take-down-bullying/>)

- LGBTQ Bullying (<http://www.oneworldeducation.org/our-students-writing/lgbtq-bullying/>).
- Help students present their proposed anti-cyberbullying policy changes and evidence-based arguments to school/district leader(s) (<https://my.pblworks.org/resource/working-outside-experts>), for example:
 - Meet with the leader(s) first to listen to their concerns and learn the process for proposing new policies
 - Propose their policies in writing then having a follow-up meeting with the leader(s) to learn the outcome of their proposals
 - Present their proposal to the leader (and possibly other stakeholders) in a forum such as a staff or leadership team meeting or school board meeting
 - Note: Depending on the format, note that this may involve submitting forms, mailing letters, or arranging for students to attend school/district meetings.
- If students will be giving oral presentations, be sure to give them opportunities to practice and use self- and peer feedback against the PBLWorks Success Skills: Complex Communication 6–12 rubric (<https://drive.google.com/file/d/1DLO69YZGtPHyQ8s8HhQDJPDx2tCUKsU3/view>) to improve.

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